INTERNATIONAL MORALITY

International morality is not only difficult to define but it also involves a cumbersome exercise to understand its effectiveness on the actions of states in pursuit of their national power. In such a discussion, there is always a chance of either overestimating the impact of ethics or underestimating its influence on the actions of statesmen and diplomats. If international politics is perceived as a Hobbesian state of nature, then the statesmen and diplomats would exceed all limits to pursue their power objectives. In reality, however, they do much less than they actually could have done and this is because their actions violate or are limited by certain moral rules. The restraining function of the moral rules is “most obvious and most effective in affirming the sacredness of human life in times of peace”. [8] This is international morality which consists of moral principles agreed upon by the comity of nations. They comprise rules of customary international law, general principles, conventions and treaties.

The sanctions behind international morality are domestic public opinion and world public opinion. While domestic public opinion is an internal constraint on the foreign policy decision-makers, world public opinion is the external restraint on the actions of statesmen and diplomats. It is for their own interests that the states subject themselves to such restraints. States are always concerned with their image and in no way can risk jeopardizing their ‘decent’ image by dishonouring domestic or world public opinion. Even, a superpower like the United States, due to its heavy involvement in the Vietnam War in the 1960s, had to succumb ultimately to the growing adverse domestic as well as world public opinion.

Role of International Morality

Morgenthau highlights the importance of international morality. According to him, it has three dimensions.

1. ***Protection of Human Life in Peace:*** The Covenant of the League of Nations contained and the Charter of the United Nations contains provisions regarding the use of force by states. Force can